these documents in alignment with national priorities. Constituency members may influence the content, but the leading state's preferences typically dominate.

Given their covert nature, we hypothesize that populist-led countries submit more Grays than their nonpopulist-led counterparts. Populists, who face greater domestic costs from overt IMF engagement, are expected to rely heavily on private communication channels. Both qualitative and quantitative evidence supports this hypothesis. Interviews with IMF staff reveal that populist leaders often adopt a dual approach, publicly criticizing the Fund while privately cooperating through their EDs. One official noted that even when leaders publicly distance themselves from the IMF, their EDs "gloss over differences" and "try not to make enemies with staff or management."[8]

Historical examples illustrate this dynamic. Venezuelan populist Hugo Chávez publicly denounced the IMF and threatened to exit the institution but remained an active participant in private.[9] Under Donald Trump, the United States maintained regular behind-the-scenes engagement with the IMF despite Trump's dismissive rhetoric.[10] Similarly, Poland submitted significantly more Grays under populist governments (2005–2007, 2015–2017) than under nonpopulist leadership, suggesting a strategic reliance on covert channels.[11]

To delve deeper into the content of Grays, we employed Latent Dirichlet Allocation topic modeling. After pre-processing the documents to remove extraneous elements (e.g., punctuation and stop words), we identified nine coherent topics, ranging from global financial markets to labor and employment issues. Figure 6.2 illustrates the temporal salience of these topics, revealing shifts in focus that align with global economic shocks and helping to validate their use. For instance, concerns about labor and employment spiked during the early 1990s recession and the 2007–2009 Great Recession.

6.3.1 Statistical Analysis

To evaluate whether populist leaders rely more heavily on private engagement with the IMF than their nonpopulist counterparts, we employ our measure of private participation: the submission of pre-meeting